

AI SEO Checklist: 30-Minute Pre-Publish Audit

Run these 24 checks on every new article before it goes live: eight timed sections, 30 minutes, one verdict.

Article: _____ Reviewer: _____ Date: _____

B = blocker. If any blocker fails, hold the post.

1. Direct-answer opening

3 min 00:00–03:00

- ☐ 1.1 **B** The first sentence answers the title's question.
Pass: read alone, it's a full answer with its key number or condition.
- ☐ 1.2 The opening is two or three sentences and under about 60 words.
Pass: count the words before the first paragraph break.
- ☐ 1.3 The answer states its scope: who, where or when it applies.
Pass: any answer that changes by country, plan, size or date says which one.

2. Source attribution

4 min 03:00–07:00

- ☐ 2.1 **B** Every number, quote and "research shows" claim links to its source where it's used.
Pass: every highlighted number has a link in the same sentence.
- ☐ 2.2 Links go to the primary source, not a roundup that quotes it.
Pass: each link lands on the study, the vendor's doc, the law or the dataset.
- ☐ 2.3 The source is named in the sentence, not only linked.
Pass: no bare "here" or "this study" links.

3. Claim verification

6 min 07:00–13:00

- ☐ 3.1 **B** Each linked number matches its source: same figure, unit, year and scope.
Pass: every source opened and ticked. Any mismatch fixed or cut.
- ☐ 3.2 Claims with no source are cut, or rewritten as your own labelled view.
Pass: no number, "study" or "expert" left without a link or a label.
- ☐ 3.3 Fast-moving facts carry a date.
Pass: every price, statistic, feature, law and "best" claim has a month and year.

4. Entity clarity

4 min 13:00–17:00

- ☐ 4.1 Each section names its subject in full, not "it", "we" or "the tool".
Pass: the first sentence under every H2 names the subject.
- ☐ 4.2 Key terms are defined once ("X is a Y that Z"), and abbreviations are spelled out.
Pass: the two or three core terms each have a definition sentence.
- ☐ 4.3 Article markup names the author, headline and dates, and matches the page.
Pass: the Rich Results Test shows no errors, and the byline and dates match what readers see.

5. Semantic headings

3 min 17:00–20:00

- ☐ 5.1 One H1 and no skipped heading levels.
Pass: a heading checker shows one H1 and no jump from H2 to H4.
- ☐ 5.2 Each H2 and H3 names its topic or asks its sub-question.
Pass: read alone, the headings say what each section answers. No "Overview" or "Wrapping up".
- ☐ 5.3 The first sentence under each heading answers that heading.
Pass: spot-check every H2.

6. Tables and lists

3 min 20:00–23:00

- ☐ 6.1 Comparisons of three or more items sit in an HTML table with a header row.
Pass: no paragraph walks through "A costs this, B costs that, C costs the other."
- ☐ 6.2 Tables and charts are text, not screenshots.
Pass: you can select the table's text on the preview page.
- ☐ 6.3 Steps are a numbered list, one action per item.
Pass: every process with an order is numbered, and each step makes sense alone.

7. Crawl accessibility

4 min 23:00–27:00

- ☐ 7.1 **B** The final URL returns a 200 status and its canonical tag points to itself.
Pass: a status check shows 200, and the canonical is the post's own URL.
- ☐ 7.2 **B** The answer, tables and FAQ are in the HTML the server sends, not loaded by JavaScript or hidden in tabs.
Pass: the raw HTML contains the opening, one table cell and one FAQ answer.
- ☐ 7.3 The post is linked from a live page and listed in the XML sitemap.
Pass: a related post or the blog index links to it, and the sitemap lists the URL.

8. AI crawler directives

3 min 27:00–30:00

- ☐ 8.1 **B** robots.txt allows Googlebot, Bingbot, OAI-SearchBot, Claude-SearchBot and PerplexityBot on the post's path.
Pass: a robots.txt tester shows "allowed" for each.
- ☐ 8.2 **B** No unintended noindex, nosnippet, small max-snippet, noarchive or nocache rule in the page or its X-Robots-Tag header.
Pass: the page source and headers show only rules you meant to set.
- ☐ 8.3 Your CDN or firewall lets verified search crawlers through.
Pass: the search category is allowed, with no new rule since your last check.

Total time: 3 + 4 + 6 + 4 + 3 + 3 + 4 + 3

30 minutes

Score: _____ of 24 checks _____ of 7 blockers

Verdict (circle one)

- ☐ **Ship** All 7 blockers pass and at least 20 of 24 checks pass.
- ☐ **Fix, then ship** All blockers pass and 16 to 19 checks pass. Fix the misses the same day.
- ☐ **Hold** Any blocker fails, or fewer than 16 checks pass.